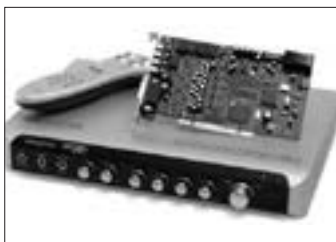


The X-Fi is the latest and greatest offering from Creative. There's the X-Fi XtremeMusic, the X-Fi Platinum, the X-Fi Fatal1ty, and the X-Fi Elite Pro. The Fatal1ty accelerates gaming performance with its 64 MB of onboard X-RAM, as does the Elite Pro.



As with the Audigy 4 Pro and other Audigy solutions, the X-Fi Elite Pro, Platinum and Fatal1ty consist of a PCI card that connects to an external hub that's controlled by a remote.

The Elite Pro is priced at approximately \$350 in the US, the Fatal1ty is about \$225, and the Platinum is about \$165. As an example of the price difference for these products between the US and India, the XtremeMusic is about \$110 (Rs 5,200) in the US, and is Rs 9,000 in India (street price).

## 1.2 Speakers

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A primary consideration in deciding between 2.1 and 5.1 speaker sets is whether it's music you're intending to use them for on the one hand, or DVD movies and games on the other.

2.1 speaker sets are ideally suited for music—more so than 5.1 systems. A good 2.1 speaker set will outperform a 5.1 set in the same price range if MP3 tracks and audio CDs is what you'll be listening to. This is because most music, such as that on a regular CD, is encoded for two-channel playback. When you play these on 5.1 speakers, your sound card is encoding stereo sound into 5.1, and there is bound to be some distortion. It's pretty straightforward, really: it was recorded on two channels, so it'll sound better on two channels... The subwoofer doesn't result in too much of a distortion, because all that happens is that the low-frequency sounds get channelised to it, but hard-core audiophiles won't